sovereignty of member states".[5] Such institutions, as Groom[6] observes, would be "international, sub-national and transnational according to their needs". This, Mitrany felt, would to some degree neutralize the antagonisms of the state system by the growth of cross-cutting ties, and the development of a transnational community would emerge with different people working together for different purposes.

The outcome of such functional organizations, which are less opposed by national governments because they revolve around non-political issues and most of the time are mutually beneficial for the participating states, has a 'spillover' effect. This means "if an international cooperative venture works to mutual advantage in the sector of coal and steel production, then it whets the appetite of and creates additional administrative requirements for participating governments to enter into cooperative ventures in related functional areas, such as transportation, pollution control and eventually to political unification".[7]

Such 'spillover' effect will be reinforced by the 'learning process' and ultimately will affect the basic unit of international system—the states, the assumption being that, with the accumulation of a large variety of functional organizations linking people and their interests across national boundaries, a transformation in both national attitudes and institutions will take place. Finally, transnational and supranational attitudes and institutions would render the nation-states useless. People would voluntarily transfer their allegiance and loyalty from individual states to transnational units leading to the emergence of a new 'functional' society with chief focus on 'functional' rather than 'territory'. Therefore, following Mitrany's vision of functionalism, expanding network of international relations and agencies would erase political divisions and integrate the interests and lives of all nation-states. Hence, according to Mitrany[8], there will be "one solid international block of flats" instead of "detached national houses".

Functionalism, however, was not without criticisms. Taylor who wrote on international co-operation, contends that functionalism "is not and never intended to be, a systematic descriptive analysis".